

Paperwork Automation Starter Kit

The 5 highest-value paperwork flows for an SMB, ranked by hours recovered. Pick one this week. Build it. Measure it.

From HitLai Institute — Module S3: “AI That Does Your Paperwork”

THE PREMISE

The average SMB spends 15 hours/week on paperwork — a full-time salary going to copying numbers from PDFs into spreadsheets and re-typing the same fields into three different systems. Most of it is invisible because no single person owns it. Everyone does a piece.

You can't fix it all at once. You CAN pick the highest-value flow, set it up, and let AI + your team + your existing systems run it together. Below: the 5 flows that pay back fastest, with what to set up and what to watch.

RANKING — PICK ONE THIS WEEK

#	Flow	Typical hours/month recovered	Risk level	Right starting setting
1	Invoice intake → accounting	12-25 hrs	Low	AI acts, you approve
2	Weekly report generation	8-16 hrs	Very low	AI handles routine
3	Contract intake → key terms + calendar	6-12 hrs	Medium	AI suggests, you write
4	Customer onboarding doc collection	8-14 hrs	Low	AI acts, you approve
5	Expense receipt → bookkeeping	4-10 hrs	Low	AI handles routine

Risk = “what if AI gets it wrong?” Low risk = mistake is recoverable in seconds. Medium = a missed deadline costs real money.

FLOW 1 — INVOICE INTAKE → ACCOUNTING

Today: Vendor emails an invoice PDF. Someone opens it, types vendor + amount + line items + due date into QuickBooks/Xero, files the PDF in a folder, sets a reminder for payment.

With AI + your team + your systems: 1. Inbound email with attachment hits a watched mailbox 2. AI extracts vendor, total, line items, PO number, due date 3. Match against your vendor list — flag if new vendor 4. Create draft AP entry in your accounting system 5. Anything over \$X (you set the threshold) routes to your reviewer 6. Below threshold: scheduled for payment, filed, reconciled

Watch for: wrong line-item parsing on hand-written or scanned invoices, duplicate detection (was this invoice already paid?), tax codes — keep AI on “you approve” until you’ve seen 50 right.

What to do today (any AI tool): Pick your 5 most common vendors. Take one invoice each. Paste into Claude or ChatGPT with: *“Extract vendor name, invoice number, total, due date, and line items as JSON.”* See how good the extraction is. That’s your baseline for whether the full flow is worth it.

FLOW 2 — WEEKLY REPORT GENERATION

Today: Every Monday morning, someone pulls numbers from 3-5 systems, puts them in a spreadsheet, formats them, writes 3 sentences of context, and emails the team.

With AI + your team + your systems: 1. Scheduled trigger every Monday at 7am 2. AI pulls last week’s numbers from your CRM, accounting, and ops tools 3. AI drafts the report — same format, same metrics, with this week’s data 4. Lands in your inbox before your coffee 5. You add 2-3 sentences of context that only you can write 6. Send to the team

Watch for: date ranges (off-by-one is the #1 mistake), holidays/short weeks, when a system goes down (have a fallback).

Why this is the easiest first win: the report doesn’t have to be perfect — your team already knows the format. Even 70% accuracy from AI saves you 90% of the time. Fix the last mile yourself.

FLOW 3 — CONTRACT INTAKE → KEY TERMS + CALENDAR

Today: Signed contract comes back. Someone reads it (or doesn’t), files it somewhere, hopes to remember the renewal date 18 months from now.

With AI + your team + your systems: 1. Contract uploaded (email attachment, drag-drop, or DocuSign webhook) 2. AI extracts: parties, term length, renewal date, auto-renewal Y/N, key obligations, termination clauses 3. Calendar entries created: 60-day renewal warning, expiry date 4. Summary added to your CRM record for that customer 5. Filed in the right folder with consistent naming

Watch for: auto-renewal clauses (the most expensive thing AI can miss), unusual jurisdictions, addendums that override the main agreement. **Always have a person read once before AI files** — AI suggests, you write — until your contract types are very standardized.

Why this matters: the average SMB loses \$5K-\$50K/year to forgotten auto-renewals. This flow alone often pays for the platform.

FLOW 4 — CUSTOMER ONBOARDING DOC COLLECTION

Today: New customer signs. Onboarding email asks for 5 documents. Half get sent. Someone chases. The rest trickle in over 3 weeks. Project starts late.

With AI + your team + your systems: 1. Trigger: new customer record in your CRM 2. AI sends the onboarding email with the document list 3. As each doc arrives, AI files it, validates required fields, marks the checklist 4. Missing docs after 3 days: AI drafts a polite reminder; your team approves the send 5. All docs received: AI notifies the project lead, kicks off the kick-off meeting scheduling

Watch for: document quality (blurry photo of a contract is “received” but not usable — AI should flag this), data privacy on HR or financial docs (route to a different folder, don’t index in your shared drive).

FLOW 5 — EXPENSE RECEIPT → BOOKKEEPING

Today: You take 30 photos of receipts at the end of the month and email them to your bookkeeper. Bookkeeper types them in. You re-explain “the lunch with the client from Acme” three times.

With AI + your team + your systems: 1. You snap the receipt with your phone — sends to a watched email or chat 2. AI extracts vendor, amount, date, category (food / travel / software / etc.) 3. Matches against your card transactions if available 4. Creates draft expense entry, ready for your bookkeeper 5. Receipts that don’t auto-categorize confidently get a 30-second review from you

Watch for: personal vs business (don’t accidentally feed your grocery receipt into your business books), client attribution (the “lunch with Acme” detail still has to come from you), foreign currency.

THE HITLAI ANSWER, IN ONE LINE

AI tools, your team, your systems — running together, safely.

For paperwork: AI extracts and drafts. Your team approves what matters. Your accounting, CRM, calendar, and filing systems take what’s been approved. AI starts on “you approve” — when a flow has been right 50 times in a row, you let AI handle the routine, and your team owns the exceptions. Each flow moves at its own pace.

Works with what you’ve got — Microsoft 365, QuickBooks, Xero, your CRM, the AI you already use. What we don’t have a connector for, the platform builds automatically in minutes, reviewed before it goes live. Every step auditable.

Want help picking your first flow and setting it up live? That’s exactly what Module S3 does — bring real documents from your business. → hitlai.net/institute
